

All the king's horses

The internet is like a game of Monopoly. Google owns all the happening spots on the board, Apple manufactures the boards, Facebook is the Bank, Yahoo!'s praying for a get out of jail card, and everyone else is trying to get in on the action by providing fancy accessories. All this makes for much joy for those playing the game, until big brother walked in and kicked the living daylight out of you... just because.

Life was good. You did as you pleased, you were whoever you wanted to be, and no one knew the real you. Then Web 2.0 came along and dropped an A-Bomb on the world of make believe. Money, fame, sex, drugs, rock n roll, power struggles, bankruptcy and more all became a part of life online.

Not all of this is bad of course. What the net is doing is ensuring that we're all exposed to just about anything we want to be exposed to, and then some. There's no real division of classes, no segregation of races – rich or poor, male or female, idiot or Einstein, from all countries, in all languages, everyone's invited with open arms... like a first world country with an open border policy for all Earthmen.

Sadly, where there is plenty, there is greed, and the need to control. Just as countries want to try and control as much of the oil reserves as possible, governments are waking up to the reality that the Internet is valuable, priceless even.

Some dictatorships found out the hard way that the net could hit back, or the netizens could, at any rate. Perhaps this prompted governments to come out in the open and try and control the net. The hactivist group called Anonymous responded by hacking sites. A wrong to right a wrong?

The governments of the world, to their credit, have thus far kept their distance from the internet (with a few exceptions such as China of course), turning a blind eye to all but the heinous. Banning child pornography, for instance, is something the majority of the civilized world agrees upon. Piracy, well, not so much.

The FOSS belief is that everything should be free for everyone. Knowledge is to be shared after all, not sold. Companies whose bottomline is the only thing of concern to their stock holders obviously believe otherwise. Opinions are like...err... noses, everyone has one, and there are a billion of them out there, and who should stand in judgement of what's right and what isn't?

Was our government wrong to block Dailymotion (a video hosting site)? Perhaps. Were they wrong to block torrent sites? Perhaps not. Do you expect the world to believe that you use *thepiratebay* to download legal Linux distributions?

In a recent online chat with members of Anonymous' Indian arm, I played devil's advocate, posing these same questions to them. Whilst they had well-rehearsed answers to simple questions such as "Is piracy wrong", or "Who are Anonymous", the tones changed the minute I started challenging their thinking.

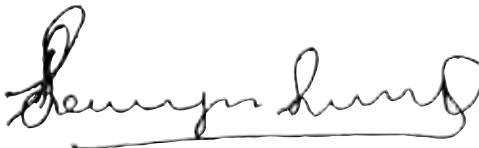
Pedophilia is illegal, so it's completely OK for governments to block that. Terrorism is the scourge of today, and we happily take off our shoes to be screened at airports, and don't mind our government snooping about to catch them. So what's the essential difference between these wrongs and breaking the law by pirating?

Everyone's scared of precedent though. Allow a government to block something that's illegal, next they want to block what's immoral. The problem is, immoral to who? If teachers can get slapped and thrown in jail for forwarding an email containing a cartoon/joke about an MP, what's next? The end of freedom of speech? Obviously no one wants that.

Something tells me that we, as people who come from the land of the Mahatma, as we celebrate our country's independence day, which was won without great wars or violence, should be able to figure the answer out.

I don't think hactivism is the real answer either. Two wrongs don't make a right, and all that. I prefer to think of the internet as the world of the future, where everyone's a global citizen, part of a hive mind that is spearheading our evolution. All of the current woes are just another battle being raised over the fertile lands. It might even get worse before it gets better, but it will get better. Eventually governments and officials will give up and move on. All of the problems we face currently are just another phase in the evolution of the internet. We will all learn from the mistakes of others and our own, and the internet will be stronger for it.

All the king's horses and all the king's men cannot fix what isn't broken... 



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